In



HEAD ABOVE WATER *Space Between Us* by Sridhar Balasubramanium

1802, MADRAS WAS THE STARTING POINT for the Great Trigonometrical Survey of India, the first colonial attempt to map the subcontinent's baseline. Home also to the Photographic Society of Madras, one of the oldest institutions of its kind in the world, the city is a fitting venue for a photo biennale. This year, the Chennai Photo Biennale's curatorial theme, *Maps of Disquiet*, strikes a sweet spot between the arc of photography since the Raj and the vital role it can play in offering a promising snapshot of the future. Currently in its third edition, the CPB will showcase the astute, sometimes moving, works of 50 local and global photographers from 12 countries. Migration, labour, archaeology, mining and other adverse effects of global capitalism are just some burning social issues *Maps of Disquiet* hopes to address through photography.

"The Great Trigonometrical Survey is deeply symbolic because the cartographic shackles of our shared history became tools for much of the political divides of the later decades. Through *Maps of Disquiet*, we want to tap into the larger mood of our times, whether it is political persecution, ecological justice, the question of land and water and who does it belong to or, in fact, the impact of Covid and how it has served as a great unifier for humanity in the past two years," says Varun Gupta, director of the biennale. One of the four curators, the Essen-based Kerstin Meincke adds, "A major guiding force for us has been Arjun Appadurai's book *Fear of Small Numbers*, which served as a reference point in exploring growing hostilities against minorities and other hazards of globalisation."

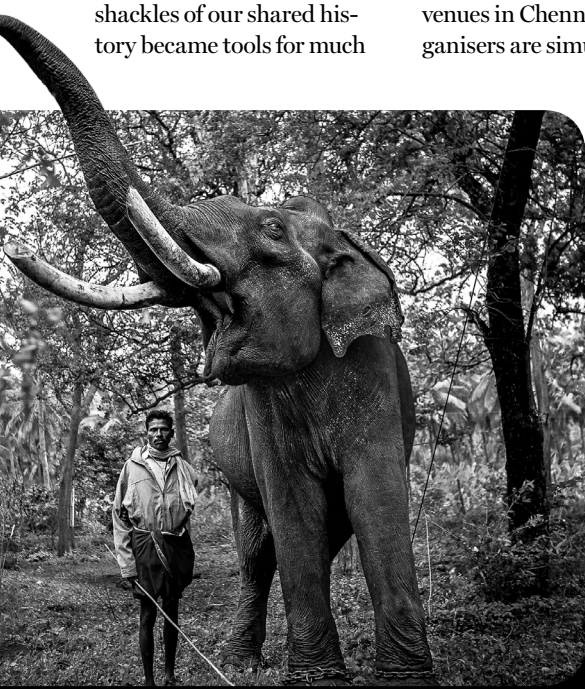
Though the biennale is spread across multiple venues in Chennai, the organisers are simultaneously working on making the full display available online in the form of a digital edition. What's more, a free-to-order book is also on its way, so that remote viewers can "have their own private exhibition".

The event might not be as grand as previous editions, but Gupta insists there is enough diversity and fresh perspective for everyone. Highlights include Gauri Gill's ongoing photobook examining the 1984 anti-Sikh pogrom, Senthil Kumaran's wildlife portraits and Parvathi Nayar and her niece Nayantara Nayar's multidisciplinary project *Chicken Run,* resurrecting India's forgotten role in the Korean War. The environment is a conspicuous theme, especially in the works of photographers like Katrin Koenning, Anaïs Tondeur and Carolina Caycedo. Gupta, for his part, recommends *Excavating an Imagination*, a collaborative project between the German Andreas Langfeld and Sarabhi Ravichandran. It combines photographs, films, found footage and interviews with experts from the field of archaeology, history and journalism. Centred around the Keezhadi excavation site in Tamil Nadu's Sivagangai district, "it reinterprets the cultural identity and historical narratives in the larger Vaigai civilisation of the state."

Launched in 2016, the Chennai Photo Biennale is the brainchild of Gupta, himself a photographer. When he returned to Chennai in 2006 after a stint in the US, he was shocked to discover that photographers like him had no easy access to exhibition outlets. "I felt if photography has to grow into something everybody appreciates then it has to step out of the gallery format," he says. Now, his aim is to make Chennai a global art hub—"the ultimate rallying point for photographers". ■

–Shaikh Ayaz

The Chennai Photo Biennale 2021 is on till February 6



A SPECIAL RELATIONSHIP
Tamed Tuskers by Senthil Kumaran (2016-2021)

calmest elephants in Mudumalai. Though I stayed there for 20 days and eagerly photographed Moorthy, I was honestly scared of approaching him. One day, when the mahout was away, I slowly went ahead and touched him. He responded with so much love and trust.

Q. Are we doing enough to protect these endangered animals?

Efforts are being made, but not enough. Firstly, their habitats are shrinking. In the past 30 years, India has lost almost 30,000 sq. kms of forest reserve. Humans have directly destroyed the elephant corridors. We are greedy for raw materials. We need paper, iron, aluminium, wood, medicine etc. Animals don't need all this. Animals have no care for urbanisation. So why do they have to suffer because of our greed? ■

–with Shaikh Ayaz